Furthermore, NEGVAC had also brainstormed on the list of the initial recipients of the vaccine based on the WHO's recommendations which would include three crore people with maximum risk exposure. One crore doctors and two crore healthcare workers, central and state police forces, home guards, Armed Forces, municipal and Asha workers would be inoculated on priority.

28 NOVEMBER 2020

INDIA | 4,54,231 ACTIVE CASES | 1,37,647 DEATHS

WORLD | 1,37,83,062 ACTIVE CASES | 15,54,518 DEATHS

Over the past several months, the prime minister had been hearing upbeat news about various Indian vaccine manufacturers and their noteworthy developments in putting India as a frontrunner in the race for COVID-19 vaccines. Now that several of the vaccine candidates were in the final stages of trials, he wanted to personally visit the teams, the scientists and the experts who were about to play a life-changing role in the life of all Indians, and perhaps, even in many other countries around the world. No amount of gratitude and encouragement was enough for these warriors, but he wasn't one for sitting it out. As a science enthusiast, so much so that he brought the Ministry of Science and Technology under him in the recent Cabinet expansion, he just had to visit these facilities, understand the manufacturing process and see for himself. Both his advisors also point out that he has a knack for sifting through scientific information which is ever-evolving and squeezing out the critical takeaways, a job which they say is a very difficult one for a leader.

There was one other thing occupying the prime minister's mind, 'Would a population accustomed over the years to receive and trust foreign-made vaccines be able to accept an Indian one?' Perhaps his visit to the facilities would also lend authenticity and become a trust-building exercise. India could not afford vaccine hesitancy at his point in time. Ahead of the visit, the PMO had tweeted, 'As India enters a decisive phase of the fight against COVID-19, PM @narendramodi's visit to these facilities & discussions with the scientists will help him get a first-hand perspective of the